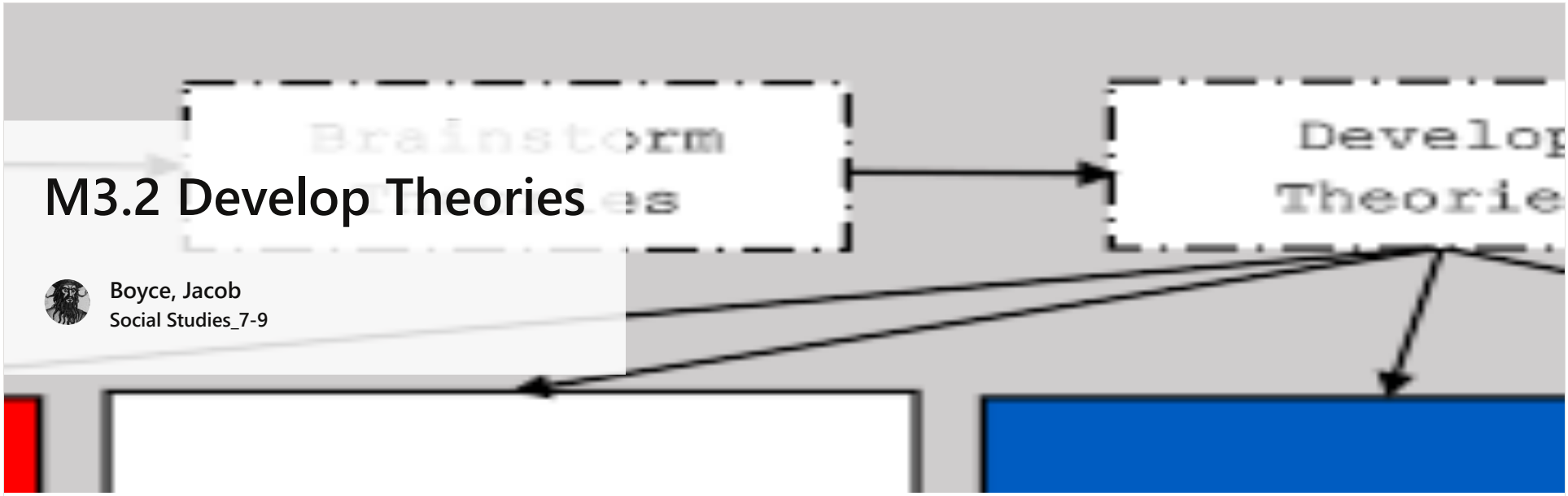


M3.2 Develop Theories

Boyce, Jacob
Social Studies_7-9

Theory Development

In these lessons, we will learn to develop clear theories because having precise and well-structured theories is essential for understanding and discussing ideas effectively. A clear theory helps everyone communicate better and allows for meaningful discussions. If a theory is vague or confusing, it can lead to misunderstandings and make it harder to explore the topic. By focusing on clarity, we ensure that our theories are understandable and grounded in solid reasoning.

It's important for our theories to meet specific criteria, such as being falsifiable and testable. A good

Overarching Question:
How do the tools of structured analysis lead to more accurate conclustions?

Objectives:
~ show understanding of the standard based on discussion
~ discuss beliefs
~ express criticality of beliefs
~ accept others being critical of beliefs

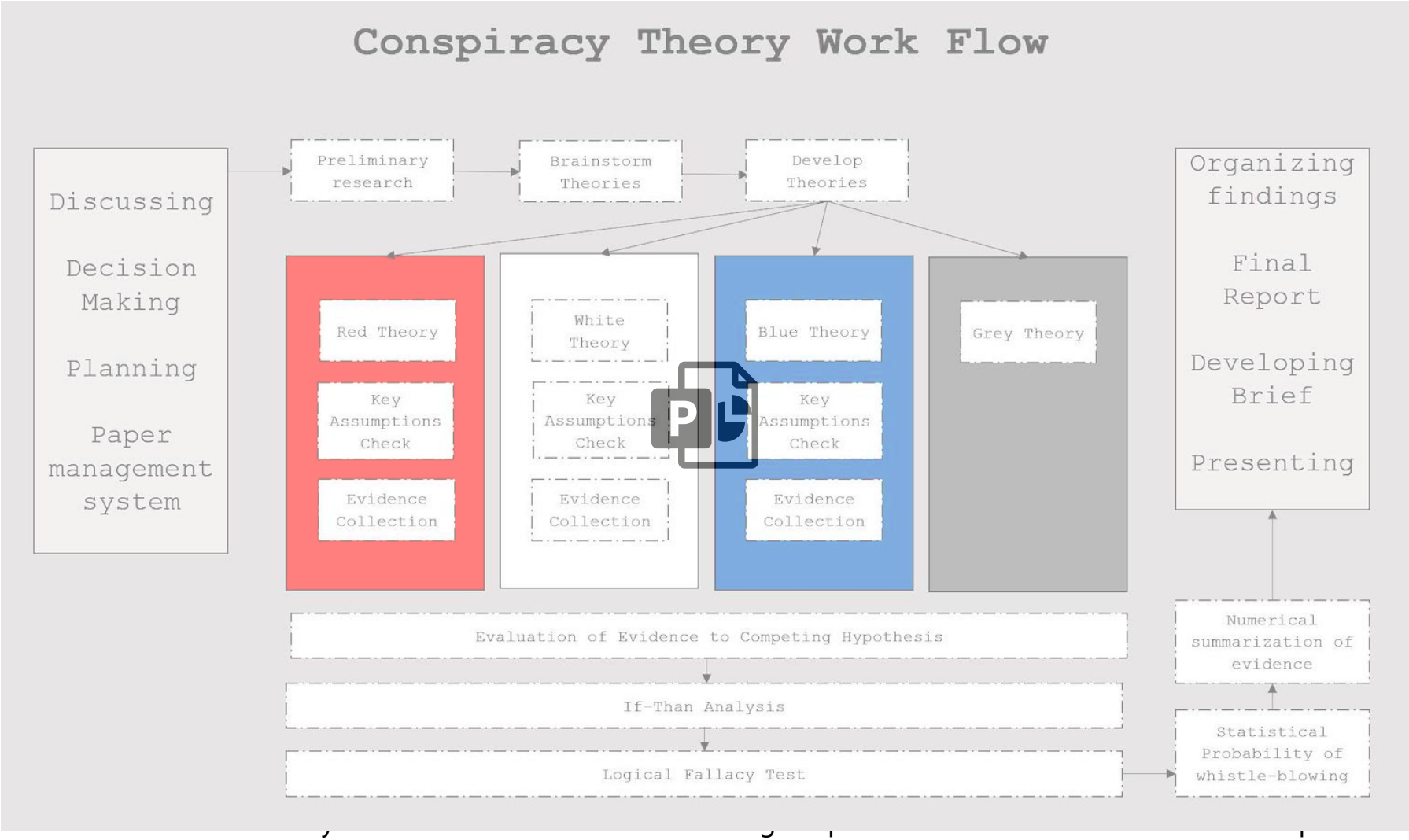
M3.2
Module 3.2 Class 1
Agenda 1120-1220, 1255-1355+:

theory should be able to be tested through observation or experimentation, and it should be structured so that it can be proven false if it turns out to be wrong. This way, we can assess whether our theories are valid and reliable. As we create our own theories, we will practice making them clear and open to investigation, which will improve our critical thinking skills and deepen our understanding of the subjects we study.

1120-1125: ACH Process Check-in
1125-1145: Theory of theory writing lecture
1145-1200: Theory of theory writing applied to conspiracy theory game
Lunch
1255-1345: Theory development
1255-1345: Episode 3: The Theories scripting
1345-1355: Recording Episode 3: The Theories recording
+ When Theories go wrong discussion
+ When personal theories go wrong discussion

Standards:
CC.8.6.9-10.A
Develop claim(s) and counterclaims fairly and thoroughly, supplying the most relevant data and evidence for each while pointing out the strengths and limitations of both claim(s) and counterclaims in a discipline appropriate form that anticipates the audience's knowledge level, concerns, values, and possible biases.

The Theory of theory writing



to make specific, observable predictions.

- **Success Example**: The theory that COVID-19 was caused by a natural virus jumping from animals to humans can be tested by genetic analysis of virus samples and tracing its origin in wildlife populations.
- **Failure Example**: A theory stating that "higher powers" control world events is untestable because it does not specify who these powers are, how they exert control, and lacks any measurable or observable predictions.

Using the information gathered in your "preliminary research and brainstorm theories stage," develop 4 theories that can compete with one another. Your theories must be carefully crafted

Theory Writing Score

- **Clarity**
  - **Score 1**: As clear as the official story about the moon landing; specific and well-supported by evidence.
  - **Score 0.5**: Generally clear but could use more specific details or examples.
  - **Score 0**: Broad statements with some relevant details; needs more specificity.
  - **Score -0.5**: Vague with significant gaps in logic or explanation.
  - **Score -1**: Extremely vague or entirely speculative without any concrete details.
- **Falsifiability**
  - **Score 1**: Contains specific predictions that can clearly be proven false, similar to the theory about a missile at the Pentagon.
- **Testability**
  - **Score 1**: The theory makes precise predictions that can be tested through current scientific methods, like the origin of COVID-19.
  - **Score 0.5**: Predictions are testable but may require considerable effort or resources beyond typical means.
  - **Score 0**: Predictions are vague or too broad, making testing feasible but not straightforward.
  - **Score -0.5**: Contains elements that might be observed but lacks clear avenues for testing.
  - **Score -1**: Completely untestable claims, as with the control by higher powers.

- **Score 0.5**: Makes predictions that are somewhat testable but may not cover all aspects of the theory.
- **Score 0**: Lacks specific predictions that would allow it to be easily falsified.
- **Score -0.5**: Broad claims that are difficult to test due to lack of specificity.
- **Score -1**: Claims are entirely non-falsifiable, like the influence of aliens on historical events.

Example of a Theory

Episode 3: The Theories

When Theories Go Wrong

Domino Theory

Background: The Domino Theory was the belief that if one country in a region fell to communism, neighboring countries would also fall, like a row of dominos. This theory was a significant justification for U.S. involvement in various conflicts during the Cold War, especially in Vietnam.

Action Taken:

- **Military Involvement in Vietnam:** U.S. policymakers believed that failing to stop the spread of communism in Vietnam would lead to the fall of other countries in Southeast Asia, such as Laos, Cambodia, and beyond. This belief justified increased military involvement and support for anti-communist regimes in the region.
- **Support for Regimes:** The U.S. provided military and financial support to governments in countries perceived as vulnerable to communist influence, often ignoring their internal issues and the desire for self-determination among their populations.

Consequences:

- **Escalation of the Vietnam War:** The commitment to the Domino Theory contributed to the escalation of U.S. military presence in Vietnam, leading to a protracted conflict that resulted in substantial loss of life, including over 58,000 American soldiers and millions of Vietnamese.
- **Destabilization of the Region:** The focus on combating communism led to U.S. involvement in various military operations across Southeast Asia, resulting in long-term instability in countries like Laos and

Cambodia, which experienced their own conflicts and genocides as a result of the Vietnam War's fallout.
- **Public Disillusionment:** Over time, as the war dragged on and public opinion shifted, many Americans began to question the validity of the Domino Theory. The perception that U.S. actions in Vietnam were based on flawed reasoning contributed to a broader distrust of government and foreign policy.

Disproval of the Theory: After the Vietnam War, many historians and analysts concluded that the Domino Theory was overstated. The spread of communism in Southeast Asia did not follow the predicted pattern, as countries like Thailand and Indonesia did not fall to communism despite the U.S. failure in Vietnam. The reality was far more complex than the simplistic view of a domino effect.

Discussion Points for Students

- **Critical Examination of Theories:** How do theories shape policy decisions, and what happens when those theories are later disproven?
- **Complexity of Historical Events:** Discuss the complexity of historical events and the dangers of oversimplifying situations into theories.
- **Lessons in Policy Making:** What lessons can policymakers learn from the impact of the Domino Theory on U.S. foreign policy and military interventions?

Theory of U.S. Aggressive Expansionism

Background: During the Cold War, particularly in the late 1940s and throughout the 1950s, Soviet leaders believed that the United States was engaged in a strategy of aggressive expansionism aimed at encircling the Soviet Union and undermining its influence worldwide. This belief was fueled by various factors, including U.S. military actions, foreign policy decisions, and propaganda that portrayed the U.S. as a threat to global communism.

Action Taken:

- **Military Buildup:** In response to the perceived threat from the U.S., the Soviet Union significantly increased its military capabilities, including the development of nuclear weapons and conventional forces. This buildup was intended to deter U.S. actions and protect the Soviet sphere of influence.

- **Support for Proxy Wars:** The Soviets supported communist movements and governments in various regions, including Asia, Africa, and Latin America, under the belief that they were countering U.S. imperialism. This included providing military and financial support to regimes in Korea, Vietnam, and Cuba.

Consequences:

- **Increased Global Tensions:** The Soviet perception of U.S. aggression contributed to heightened tensions during the Cold War, leading to events like the Cuban Missile Crisis, where both superpowers stood on the brink of nuclear war.
- **Proxy Conflicts:** The theory fueled numerous proxy wars where the U.S. and the Soviet Union supported opposing sides, such as in Vietnam, Korea, and Afghanistan, leading to significant loss of life and destabilization in those regions.
- **Arms Race:** The belief in U.S. expansionism contributed to an ongoing arms race, resulting in massive military expenditures on both sides that impacted their economies and led to long-term security dilemmas.

Disproval of the Theory: In the years following the Cold War, it became evident that while the U.S. was indeed active in many regions, its actions were often more reactive than aggressive, driven by specific geopolitical interests rather than a broad strategy of encirclement. For example, U.S. involvement in Korea and Vietnam was largely framed as a response to the spread of communism, rather than a premeditated plan to expand its influence. Additionally, many Soviet leaders misinterpreted U.S. intentions, viewing defensive measures or support for allied nations as aggressive actions.

Discussion Points for Students

- **Understanding Motivations:** How important is it to understand the motivations and perceptions of other nations in international relations?
- **Impact of Misinformation:** Discuss how theories about another country's intentions can lead to escalated military actions and conflicts, even when those theories are based on misinterpretations.
- **Lessons for Diplomacy:** What lessons can be learned about the importance of communication and transparency between nations to prevent misunderstandings and conflicts?

The Theory of Saddam Hussein's WMD Development

Background: In the lead-up to the 2003 invasion of Iraq, the U.S. government, along with allies, claimed that Saddam Hussein was actively developing weapons of mass destruction, including chemical, biological, and potentially nuclear weapons. This theory was rooted in Iraq's previous use of chemical weapons in the Iran-Iraq War and the 1991 Gulf War, as well as its failure to fully comply with United Nations weapons inspections following the Gulf War.

Action Taken:

- **Military Invasion of Iraq:** The U.S. government, under President George W. Bush, cited the threat posed by Saddam's purported WMD program as a primary justification for the invasion of Iraq in March 2003. The administration framed the invasion as a necessary action to prevent a potential WMD attack on the U.S. or its allies.
- **Global Coalition:** The belief in WMDs garnered support from various allies and resulted in a coalition of forces that participated in the invasion, despite significant opposition and skepticism from other nations and international bodies.

Consequences:

- **Overthrow of Saddam Hussein:** The invasion led to the rapid overthrow of Saddam Hussein's regime. However, the subsequent occupation faced significant challenges, including widespread insurgency and sectarian violence.
- **Destabilization of Iraq:** The power vacuum left by the removal of Saddam's regime contributed to the rise of extremist groups, including ISIS, and ongoing conflict in the region.
- **Human and Economic Cost:** The war resulted in significant loss of life, with hundreds of thousands of Iraqi civilians and over 4,500 U.S. military personnel killed, as well as long-term economic costs for the U.S. and Iraq.
- **Erosion of Trust:** The failure to find substantial WMD stockpiles or programs after the invasion led to widespread criticism of the intelligence that had justified the war. This eroded public trust in the U.S. government and its intelligence agencies.

Disproval of the Theory: After the invasion, extensive searches by U.S. and coalition forces failed to uncover any WMDs in Iraq. Subsequent investigations revealed that the intelligence used to support the theory of Saddam's active WMD program was flawed, based on misinterpretations and overstatements by various intelligence agencies. The Iraq Survey Group concluded in 2004 that Iraq had dismantled its WMD programs years before the invasion.

Discussion Points for Students

- **Importance of Evidence in Decision Making:** How critical is it to base military actions on solid evidence, and what happens when decisions are made based on unverified theories?
- **Consequences of Misguided Theories:** Discuss the long-term impacts of the invasion of Iraq on global politics, security, and public trust.
- **Lessons for Future Policy:** What lessons can be learned about the role of intelligence and the need for accountability in government actions, particularly in matters of war?

When Personal Theories Go Wrong

Discussion Questions

1. **Reflecting on Personal Experiences:**
    - Can you think of a time when you misjudged a situation or made an assumption about something in your life? What was the outcome, and how did you feel afterward?
    - Have you ever acted on a belief that later turned out to be untrue? What led you to that belief, and what did you learn from the experience?
4. **Impact of Misunderstandings:**
    - Share an experience where a friend misunderstood you or your intentions. How did that

misunderstanding affect your relationship, and how was it resolved?
- Have you ever had a misunderstanding with a peer that escalated into a conflict? What could have been done differently to avoid the situation?

7. **Learning from Mistakes:**
   - What strategies can you use to verify information before acting on it, whether it's regarding your own feelings or those of your friends?
   - How can you approach a situation when you realize you've made a mistake based on an incorrect assumption? What steps can you take to rectify it?

10. **Empathy and Communication:**
    - How important is it to communicate openly with friends about your thoughts and feelings to prevent misunderstandings? Can you provide an example of when good communication helped clarify a situation?
    - In what ways can understanding others' perspectives help prevent misinterpretations in friendships? Can you recall a time when empathy changed the way you viewed a situation?

13. **Consequences of Actions:**
    - Reflect on a time when someone acted on incorrect information about you. What impact did it have on your relationship, and how did you address the situation?
    - Have you ever witnessed a situation where someone acted on a rumor or misconception? What were the consequences, and what lessons did you take away from that experience?